

Practice Paper 11 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Atmosphere of the depot

1 mark for identifying that the atmosphere is **unemotional** / **matter-of-fact** / **no-fuss**.

1 mark for explaining that the men of the depot deliberately **do not mark** personal milestones such as a retirement — work is treated as routine, not as occasion.

Sample answer: The depot is a **practical, no-nonsense** place in which the workers **avoid open displays of feeling**. Even on the narrator's final morning, his retirement passes **without acknowledgement**, because the culture of the depot is to treat work as work and not as ceremony.

Q2. [1] — Detail showing action by habit

1 mark for any **one** of:

- He walked the length of the bus “tapping the tyres **out of habit**”.
- He recognised the smell of the depot as one he had known “as it had smelled for thirty-one years”.
- He “signed for the keys of Bus 47” as part of a routine sequence.

Q3. [2] — “The rooms of an old house”

1 mark for identifying that the comparison conveys **deep, intimate familiarity** — the route is known **without conscious thought**.

1 mark for explaining that the comparison also makes the route feel **personal** and **home-like**, not merely professional — the road is a place the narrator **inhabits**, not just one he travels.

Q4. [2] — The bus and the driver

1 mark — The bus is given a **personality** / treated almost like a **living companion** (personification).

1 mark — It suggests an **unspoken understanding** / **partnership** between driver and machine:

after thirty-one years, the bus **anticipates** his actions, showing how **seamlessly joined** they have become.

Q5. [2] — “We did not need to”

1 mark — It suggests a **quiet, mutual understanding**: the woman’s grief and routine are **plainly visible**, and the driver **respects** her silence rather than intruding upon it.

1 mark — It also tells us something about the narrator: he is **observant, discreet**, and content to offer his service **without demanding words** in return.

Q6. [2] — “Careful, dignified walk... drunk more than he had meant to”

1 mark — **Unusual**: The word **dignified** is normally used of people who are sober and composed; pairing it with a drunk man creates a **deliberate contradiction / oxymoron**.

1 mark — **Suggestion**: The narrator views the man with **sympathy and respect** rather than contempt — he sees him as a person trying to **preserve his dignity** in difficult circumstances, not as a nuisance.

Q7. [2] — “The way one walks towards a strange dog”

1 mark — The comparison shows the driver moving **slowly, calmly, with no sudden gestures**, signalling that he is **not a threat**.

1 mark — It also suggests the driver **understands** that the passenger, like a frightened animal, is **unpredictable** and could become defensive if startled — so he handles him with **patience and caution**.

Q8. [2] — “Anger went out of his face the way air goes out of a tyre”

1 mark — **Gradual**: Air leaves a tyre **slowly and steadily**, not in a sudden burst; this suggests the man’s anger **deflates gently over a moment**, not all at once.

1 mark — **Complete**: A deflated tyre is **entirely empty**; the image suggests his anger leaves him **fully**, with nothing left behind — only weariness and sorrow.

Q9. [1] — Why he “did not say I was sorry”

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- The phrase would have been **empty / inadequate** in the face of real grief.
- The narrator chose **practical kindness** (offering a warm seat, a safe ride home) over **empty words**.
- He sensed that the man did not want to be **pitied**, only to be **cared for quietly**.

Q10. [2] — The narrator’s character

1 mark — He is **modest / unassuming**; he takes no pleasure in **being seen** to do his job well, and feels no need for applause or witnesses.

1 mark — He values **personal satisfaction** and **quiet professionalism** over recognition; the **act** of doing the work properly is its own reward.

Q11. [2] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark for identifying the tone — any **one** of: **bittersweet, wistful, reflective, tender, gently melancholic.**

1 mark for explaining the tone: the narrator accepts that **the route, the passengers, and the small unspoken bonds will continue without him** — a thought that is **moving but not bitter**. (Reject: **sad, angry, resentful** — these miss the accepting quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Attitude of local reporters

1 mark — The reporters approached their work as a **settled duty / routine responsibility**, not as a matter of glamour or excitement (“sheer habit”).

1 mark — They were **uncomplaining / dependable**: they covered the small, unspectacular events of community life (“school sports results”) **without resentment**, because they understood that those events mattered to local readers.

Q13. [2] — Economic reasons for decline

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Classified advertising** has moved to free online platforms.
- **Display advertising** has gone to the two large American technology companies that dominate digital ad spending.
- **Print circulation** has fallen sharply (halved, and halved again).
- Owners have responded by **cutting staff**, reducing the paper’s capacity further.

Q14. [2] — State of small-town journalism

1 mark — Small-town newsrooms are **severely understaffed**: a single reporter is expected to cover **several different subject areas** (beats) at once.

1 mark — The work is **exhausting and unsustainable**; the journalist has no proper team, only **part-time support**, suggesting that the quality and breadth of coverage must inevitably suffer.

Reject: lifting “exhausted journalist with three beats” without rewording.

Q15. [2] — One practical consequence

1 mark for **naming** a consequence and **1 mark** for **explanation**. Any **one** of:

- **Higher borrowing costs:** Without local journalists to scrutinise officials, **investors lose confidence** that public money is being well managed and **charge higher interest rates** to lend to the town.
- **Lower voter turnout:** Without reliable local reporting, **fewer residents understand or engage with local elections**, so participation falls.
- **Fewer volunteers:** Civic associations find it **harder to recruit members**, because there is **no shared public record** through which to advertise community work.

Q16. [2] — Effect of “doing rather more than anyone had noticed”

1 mark — The phrase is **understated** (deliberately quiet language for an important point); this **mirrors** the writer’s argument that the value of the local paper was **itself unnoticed**.

1 mark — Placing the line at the **end** of the paragraph gives it the force of a **quiet conclusion / reveal**: the reader, having just absorbed the evidence, is invited to **re-evaluate** the modest local paper as a **crucial civic institution**.

Q17. [2] — “Tedious” and “dispiriting”

1 mark — The words are **deliberately unflattering**; the writer is **honest** about the unglamorous nature of professional journalism (long meetings, careful checking, slow extraction of facts).

1 mark — By admitting this, the writer **strengthens his point**: citizen reporters are unlikely to do this **dull but essential** work, so professional journalism **cannot be fully replaced** by enthusiastic amateurs.

Q18. [2] — Newspaper as shared document vs feed as bespoke

1 mark — A **newspaper** offers **every reader the same edition**, so residents discuss the **same stories and facts**; it creates a **common ground** for the town.

1 mark — A **social-media feed** shows **each reader a different selection**, tailored by an algorithm to their interests and biases; it therefore **separates** readers into private worlds and **fragments** a shared civic conversation.

Reject: lifting “shared document... bespoke to each reader” without rewording.

Q19. [1] — “Access” in inverted commas

1 mark — The inverted commas show the writer is **distancing himself** from the word / using it **sceptically**. Paywalls treat journalism as a **product** sold to individual readers, an attitude the writer regards as **misguided** (it “having proved... mostly ruinous”). The inverted commas signal that he does not endorse this framing.

Q20. [1] — Tone of “cannot be assumed”

1 mark — Any **one** of: **cautious, sober, realistic, guarded, gently pessimistic**. (Reject: **cynical, bitter, sarcastic** — these are too strong.)

Q21. [2] — “Scaffolding”

1 mark — **Scaffolding** is a **temporary, often unnoticed support structure** on which a building is constructed; the metaphor suggests the local paper was a **practical, behind-the-scenes framework** propping up civic life.

1 mark — The image is effective because scaffolding is **plain and unglamorous**, matching the writer’s earlier description of the paper as **mundane** — yet without it, the structure **cannot stand**. The metaphor captures **both** the modesty **and** the indispensability of the local press.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.

What is lost when a local paper closes (Paragraphs 3–5):

1. Towns **borrow money at higher interest rates**, because **officials are no longer scrutinised** / investors lose trust.
2. **Voter turnout falls** in local elections / civic associations struggle to **recruit volunteers**.
3. The slow, **unspectacular work of holding small powers to account** is no longer being done.
4. Citizen reporters **cannot fully replace** trained journalists, because they lack training in **libel, fact-checking, and patient coverage of long meetings**.

5. Social-media feeds **reward outrage rather than accuracy** / make readers **more polarised** and **less informed** about their own town.

Attempts now being made to replace it (Paragraph 6):

6. Some papers have become **non-profits**, funded by **foundations, philanthropic readers and university grants**.
7. Others use **reader-funded models**, in which subscribers pay to **sustain the institution** rather than for paywalled access.
8. The most-cited success (e.g. The Texas Tribune) runs on **donations and event income**, but such ventures **remain fragile** / **depend on civic generosity**.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

When a local newspaper closes, the community loses trusted scrutiny of its officials, often paying higher interest on its debts, voting less, and volunteering less. Untrained citizen reporters cannot match the patient, careful work of professionals, and social-media feeds reward outrage and divide readers. To replace what is gone, some papers have become non-profits, supported by foundations, while others are sustained by readers who pay to keep the institution alive, though such ventures remain fragile.

Length count: 78 words from “When” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —